

Prepping Kids For Future Success



More than 600 students take LIRP classes each year.

BY CHRIS BOYLE

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For many high school students, Regents and Advanced Placement (AP) tests can be the start of a glorious path towards higher education, or cause significant damage to their academic lives; it all depends on how they prepare for the big test.

Long Island Regents Prep (LIRP), based out of Farmingdale State College, was started by three industrious Bellmore-Merrick school district teachers who noted that many students today could benefit from preparation for Regents and AP tests beyond what they receive in the classroom, according to Dr. Dennis Urban, co-founder and co-owner of LIRP.

"Just talking to a lot of my

students, I realized that a lot of the test prep companies out there were run by people without a background in education, and that a lot of the tutors were college students or people who had degrees but didn't have any experience actually teaching," he said. "The three of us decided to start our own business—we were all doing Regents and AP test tutoring on the side already—and make it completely teacher-run and operated and staffed only by New York certified teachers."

Pointing out there are no real requirements in place for someone to become a tutor, Urban, along with fellow Bellmore-Merrick co-workers Brad Seidman and Michael Graziosi—all three social studies teachers—set out six years

ago on their unique, teacher-based approach to test prep by first establishing a base of operations: Farmingdale State College, where they continue to operate.

"We called up Farmingdale to rent some class space, and they were absolutely amenable to us being there...it's nice and centrally located, so we get a lot of students from both Nassau and Suffolk, and even Brooklyn and Queens," he said. "Word of mouth really spread quickly. Our first year we maybe had 100 or 200 students, but now we're at a place where we have over 600 students taking our classes each year. It's grown pretty nicely

over the past six years."

LIRP holds one-day, six-hour review classes annually during the months of May and June. Their main offering is Regents preparation classes, but they have also branched out to include AP review and even SAT "crash courses." Students come for the day, are put through the paces and leave feeling much more confident about the subject matter than when they came in, Urban said.

"Kids will get review materials and the teachers will spend time going over major topics and skills associated with the subject, and assign practice questions," he said. "Each hour addresses a different subject... for example, for a U.S. History course, I might break it down into

six chronological sections, covering up through the age of President Andrew Jackson, including practice questions and essay prompts at the end of each hour."

LIRP is continuing to grow. In addition to expanding SAT prep, they are holding classes in the fall this year for the first time ever. But aside from launching and cultivating a successful business with his fellow co-founders, Urban said that the main goal—as it has been since the beginning—is making qualified, low-cost test prep assistance available for young men and women who are looking to get a head start on a bright and promising future.

"It's been absolutely amazing... it's been very rewarding to offer something that we know is helping students, and we're so much more affordable than hiring a private tutor," he said. "We know that we can confidently say that we know what we're doing; we're all certified teachers and experienced educators. It's been a great experience."

To find out more, visit www.liregentsprep.com.



Dr. Dennis Urban